



REUBEN SINGH



E-CONNECT

Aruna Sundararajan

48, IAS officer

Aruna Sundararajan didn't plan on becoming an IAS officer. When she graduated from the University of Madras, she wanted to be an economist, but decided to take the UPSC exam and made the cut. Now on deputation as the CEO of the CSC (Common Service Centres) project at IL&FS, she aims at setting up one lakh CSCs across India in a Rs 5,700-crore project. It's a project that will bridge the digital divide, providing access to the Internet through kiosks, which are to be set up in every sixth village of India to promote rural entrepreneurship. The CSC scheme is one of the most ambitious projects under the government's national e-governance plan. "I've seen women in villages chatting with their husbands on Skype, boys in madrasas watching youtube videos and patients in Tripura getting medical advice from doctors in Madurai. It's a huge high, knowing you helped make that possible," she says. But it hasn't come easy and she's had her share of battles. "Working in the government can be restrictive, but it's also where you can make the most impact," she says.

SMARTEST INVESTMENT I bought stocks in Infosys in 2001, which haven't given me any heartburn. It's important to choose stocks based on their performance and keep tabs on the economic environment.

WORST DECISION I MADE AND THE LESSON LEARNT I had invested in funds, and when the market tanked, I pulled out quickly. The key is not to make decisions in a panic, but make an informed choice.

MOST EXTRAVAGANT GIFT A bottle of Chanel perfume that I gifted my mother.

STRESS BUSTER Long walks with my dog, Max, cooking and practising Bharatanatyam.

**USE
THIS
TIP**

"YOU HAVE TO BE PREPARED FOR SOME HITS AND MISSES, SO MAKE SURE YOU HAVE THE MINIMUM SECURITY TO BOUNCE BACK."